

Rhetorical Genre Studies: Genre as Social Action

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1 Introduction

Rhetorical Genre Studies (RGS) represents one of the most consequential paradigm shifts in contemporary writing theory. Rather than treating genres as static taxonomic categories defined by formal textual features—the inherited view from classical rhetoric and literary criticism—RGS reconceives genre as a form of social action, embedded in and constitutive of the communities that produce and consume texts. This theoretical reorientation, initiated by Carolyn R. Miller’s landmark 1984 article “Genre as Social Action,” has reshaped scholarship in rhetoric and composition, applied linguistics, professional communication, and Writing in the Disciplines (WID). The present report traces the origins, core principles, key figures, pedagogical applications, theoretical connections, criticisms, and lasting legacy of Rhetorical Genre Studies.

2 Origins: Miller’s “Genre as Social Action” and the Departure from Classical Genre Theory

For most of the Western rhetorical tradition, genre functioned as a principle of formal classification. Literary genres—epic, tragedy, lyric, comedy—were defined by their structural and thematic features. In composition and rhetoric, this formalist inheritance persisted through the twentieth century in the teaching of “modes of discourse” (narration, description, exposition, argumentation), which treated genre as a set of textual templates to be learned and reproduced. The underlying assumption was that genres are containers: stable forms into which content is poured.

Carolyn R. Miller challenged this assumption directly. In “Genre as Social Action,” published in the *Quarterly Journal of Speech* in 1984, Miller argued that “a rhetorically sound definition of genre must be centered not on the substance or the form of discourse but on the action it is used to accomplish” (Miller, 1984, p. 151). Drawing on Lloyd Bitzer’s concept of the rhetorical situation and Alfred Schutz’s phenomenological notion of typification, Miller proposed that genres are best understood as “typified rhetorical actions based in recurrent situations” (p. 159). The key move here is ontological: genres do not exist as abstract formal categories but as recognizable, socially shared responses to situations that a community perceives as recurring. The situation itself is not a material given but a social construct—communities typify certain constellations of exigence, audience, and constraint as “the same kind of situation,” and genres emerge as the conventionalized responses to those typified situations.

This reframing had several immediate consequences. First, it shifted the unit of analysis from the text to the activity. A genre is not primarily a set of textual features but a recognizable way of acting in the world through language. Second, it made genre inherently rhetorical: genres exist because they accomplish social purposes for the communities that use them. Third, it historicized genre. Because situations change and communities evolve, genres are dynamic rather than fixed; they emerge, stabilize, hybridize, and sometimes disappear. Miller’s article thus established the foundational premises of what would come to be called Rhetorical Genre Studies.

3 Core Principles

Several interrelated principles constitute the theoretical core of RGS.

Genres are defined by social action, not formal features. While genres do exhibit recurrent formal and stylistic characteristics, these features are effects rather than causes. The formal regularities of the experimental research article, for instance, exist because the scientific community has developed conventionalized ways of arguing for empirical claims. Form follows function, and function is social.

Genres are typified rhetorical actions based in recurrent situations. This principle, drawn directly from Miller, emphasizes that genre recognition is a social-cognitive process. Writers and readers

identify situations as belonging to a recognizable type and respond with (or expect) a typified form of discourse. This recognition is what Bazerman would later call a “psycho-social recognition phenomenon”—genre is not merely a textual category but a cognitive and social schema through which participants orient to communicative situations.

Genres are dynamic and evolving. Because genres are tied to social situations, and social situations change, genres are inherently historical and mutable. New genres emerge when communities face new recurrent situations (the blog post, the tweet, the environmental impact statement). Existing genres evolve as the situations they address and the communities that use them undergo transformation.

Genres mediate between individual action and social structure. This is among the most theoretically significant claims of RGS. Genres are simultaneously enabling and constraining: they provide individuals with recognizable frameworks for action (enabling participation in social activities) while also reproducing the norms, values, and power relations of the communities that sustain them. A writer composing a grant proposal, for example, is both exercising individual agency and participating in an institutional structure that defines what counts as fundable research. Genre, in this sense, is a site where structure and agency intersect.

4 Key Figures

Carolyn R. Miller is the foundational figure. Beyond the 1984 article, Miller continued to develop genre theory, addressing the relationship between genre and kairos (rhetorical timing), the implications of digital media for genre, and the broader philosophical underpinnings of genre as a concept. Her work established the intellectual framework that subsequent scholars would elaborate.

Charles Bazerman extended Miller’s insights in several crucial directions. His 1988 monograph *Shaping Written Knowledge: The Genre and Activity of the Experimental Article in Science* traced the historical development of the experimental article, demonstrating that the forms of scientific writing are not neutral vehicles for reporting findings but rhetorical solutions to persuasive problems faced by scientists arguing for the acceptance of their claims. Bazerman showed that what counts as scientific knowledge is in part constituted by the genres through which that knowledge is

communicated.

Amy J. Devitt synthesized and advanced RGS in *Writing Genres* (2004), which offered a comprehensive account of genre as a rhetorical concept and explored its implications for writing pedagogy. Devitt argued that genre “reflects, constructs, and reinforces the values, epistemology, and power relationships of the groups from which it is developed and for which it functions” (Devitt, 2004). Her central pedagogical argument—that writing instruction should aim for genre awareness rather than genre acquisition—has become a defining position within RGS-inflected composition pedagogy.

John Swales, working primarily within English for Specific Purposes (ESP) and English for Academic Purposes (EAP), brought genre analysis into applied linguistics with his 1990 book *Genre Analysis: English in Academic and Research Settings*. Swales developed the influential Create a Research Space (CARS) model for analyzing research article introductions, identifying three rhetorical “moves”—establishing a territory, establishing a niche, and occupying the niche—that characterize the genre. While Swales’s approach is more textually oriented than Miller’s, his work shares RGS’s commitment to understanding genre in relation to discourse communities and communicative purposes.

5 Bazerman’s Contributions: Genre Systems and the Social Construction of Knowledge

Bazerman’s contributions to RGS deserve extended discussion, as they represent some of the most theoretically ambitious extensions of Miller’s foundational work.

5.1 Genre Systems

In his 1994 essay “Systems of Genres and the Enactment of Social Intentions,” Bazerman introduced the concept of the genre system: the full set of interrelated genres that circulate within an organized social activity. A genre system comprises “the several genre sets of people working together in an organized way, plus the patterned relationships in the production, flow, and use of these documents” (Bazerman, 1994). The concept captures the insight that genres rarely operate in

isolation. A courtroom proceeding, for instance, involves motions, briefs, transcripts, rulings, and appeals—each a distinct genre, but all functioning as an interconnected system that constitutes legal activity. The genre system concept allows analysts to map the documentary ecology of institutions and to understand how texts organize human activity.

5.2 Speech Acts in Writing

Bazerman drew on speech act theory (Austin, Searle) to argue that written texts perform social actions—they assert, promise, declare, direct, and commit. Crucially, Bazerman argued that the felicity conditions for written speech acts are themselves matters of typification: “what kind of speech act something is perceived as and what felicity conditions it must meet for success are matters of typification” (Bazerman, 2004). This integration of speech act theory with genre theory deepens the account of how texts do things in the world.

5.3 The Social Construction of Scientific Knowledge

Shaping Written Knowledge demonstrated that the experimental article is not a transparent window onto nature but a historically evolved rhetorical form through which scientists construct and negotiate claims to knowledge. Bazerman examined how the conventions of scientific writing—the passive voice, the hedged claim, the methods section, the literature review—are rhetorical strategies that manage the social dynamics of knowledge production. The cases he examined “indicate how ways of perceiving and knowledge-making emerge out of sociolinguistic processes, and each community finds its own way to formulate its knowledge and in so doing defines what it considers knowledge to be” (Bazerman, 1988).

5.4 Typification and Social Facts

Bazerman elaborated a hierarchical model of social-textual activity: speech acts produce social facts (socially recognized states of affairs), genres typify speech acts, genre systems organize genres, and activity systems provide the broadest context of purposive human action. Each successful text “creates a social fact for its reader,” and these social facts accumulate to constitute the institutional realities within which communities operate.

6 Pedagogical Applications

RGS has generated a distinctive approach to writing pedagogy that differs sharply from both traditional formalist instruction and process-oriented approaches.

Genre awareness over genre imitation. The central pedagogical principle of RGS is that students should develop genre awareness—a critical understanding of how genres function rhetorically and ideologically—rather than merely learning to reproduce the formal features of particular genres. Devitt articulated this distinction clearly: rather than teaching students to write a five-paragraph essay or a lab report by providing templates, instructors should help students understand why genres take the forms they do, what social actions they perform, what values and epistemologies they encode, and how they might be adapted or resisted. The goal is to produce flexible, critically aware writers who can navigate unfamiliar genres by analyzing their rhetorical situations.

Analyzing genres in context. RGS-informed pedagogy emphasizes situated analysis. Students are asked to collect and examine samples of genres as they function in actual communities—workplace documents, disciplinary articles, civic discourse—and to analyze the relationship between textual features and social contexts. This approach treats genres not as decontextualized models to be imitated but as evidence of how communities construct knowledge, establish authority, and organize activity.

Understanding audience expectations through genre. Because genres encode the expectations of their communities, genre analysis provides students with a powerful tool for understanding audience. By examining the conventions of a genre, students can infer what a particular audience values, what counts as evidence, what rhetorical moves are expected, and what degree of formality or informality is appropriate. Genre becomes, in effect, a heuristic for rhetorical analysis.

Antecedent genres. Devitt introduced the concept of antecedent genres—the genres a writer has previously encountered and internalized—to explain how writers approach new writing situations. Students do not come to new genres as blank slates; they bring with them a repertoire of prior genre knowledge that shapes their expectations and strategies. Pedagogically, this concept invites instructors to help students examine and leverage their existing genre knowledge when encountering unfamiliar writing situations.

7 Connections to Other Theories

RGS is not an isolated theoretical framework but intersects productively with several cognate traditions.

Activity theory. Drawing on Vygotsky, Leontiev, and Engestrom, activity theory examines how human activity is mediated by tools, including symbolic tools such as language. Bazerman's concepts of genre systems and activity systems explicitly integrate genre theory with activity theory, treating genres as mediating artifacts within goal-directed human activity. David Russell's work on Writing in the Disciplines has similarly drawn on activity theory to understand how genres function within academic disciplinary systems.

Social constructionism. RGS shares with social constructionism the premise that knowledge, meaning, and social reality are constituted through communicative practices rather than simply reflected by them. The claim that scientific knowledge is constructed through the genres of scientific writing (Bazerman, 1988) is a paradigmatic example of social constructionist reasoning applied to genre.

Discourse community theory. Swales's concept of the discourse community—a group united by shared communicative purposes, participatory mechanisms, and genres—provides a sociological complement to RGS's rhetorical framework. Genres are the discursive instruments through which discourse communities conduct their business, and a community's norms, epistemology, and ideology are symbolized and enacted through its genre conventions.

8 Criticisms

RGS has attracted several lines of criticism.

The constraint of explicit genre teaching on creativity. Richard Coe's phrase "the tyranny of genre" captures a persistent concern: that making genre conventions explicit risks reducing writing to formulaic reproduction and constraining individual creativity. If students are taught that research articles follow a particular structure, will they simply reproduce that structure mechanically rather than engaging in genuine intellectual inquiry? RGS scholars have responded by emphasizing that

genre awareness, as opposed to genre imitation, is designed precisely to foster critical and flexible engagement with conventions rather than rote reproduction.

The breadth of the “genre as social action” definition. Some critics have argued that defining genre as “typified rhetorical action based in recurrent situations” is so broad as to be analytically unwieldy. If virtually any recurrent communicative practice qualifies as a genre, the concept risks losing its discriminating power. Where does one draw the boundary between a genre and a mere communicative routine? Miller herself acknowledged this difficulty, suggesting that genres exist at a particular level of generality in a hierarchy of rhetorical actions, but the boundary remains a matter of scholarly debate.

Difficulties in classroom application. While RGS has generated compelling theoretical accounts of genre, translating those accounts into concrete classroom practices has proven challenging. Teaching genre awareness requires students to engage in sophisticated rhetorical analysis, which may presuppose a level of disciplinary knowledge and critical sophistication that beginning writers have not yet developed. The understanding of the rhetorical and ideological dimensions of genre “remains broad and simplified, and how [students] might enact that understanding in particular contexts remains mostly a mystery to be solved” (Bawarshi & Reiff, 2010). The gap between the theoretical richness of RGS and the practical demands of the classroom remains an active area of concern.

Tensions between RGS and ESP approaches. While RGS and ESP genre analysis share intellectual heritage, they diverge on key questions. ESP scholars such as Swales and Bhatia have been more willing to engage in explicit, detailed textual description of genre features for pedagogical purposes, while RGS scholars have tended to resist such description as potentially reductive. This tension reflects deeper disagreements about whether genre pedagogy should prioritize critical awareness or practical competence.

9 Legacy

The influence of Rhetorical Genre Studies extends across multiple domains of writing scholarship and pedagogy.

ESP and EAP instruction. Swales's CARS model and the broader genre-analytic tradition have transformed how English for academic and specific purposes is taught worldwide. Genre analysis provides EAP students with systematic tools for understanding the rhetorical expectations of academic discourse communities, enabling more effective participation in disciplinary writing.

Professional writing and workplace communication. RGS has informed scholarship on professional and technical communication by providing frameworks for understanding how workplace genres organize institutional activity. The concepts of genre systems and activity systems have proven especially productive for analyzing the documentary practices of professions such as engineering, medicine, law, and business.

Writing in the Disciplines (WID). RGS has provided the theoretical foundation for much WID scholarship, which examines how disciplinary communities use genres to construct and communicate knowledge. By treating disciplinary genres not as neutral formats but as rhetorical instruments that embody epistemic values, RGS has deepened our understanding of what it means to write within a discipline.

Digital genres and new media. As communicative practices have migrated to digital platforms, RGS has provided analytical tools for understanding emerging genres. Miller and Shepherd's (2004) analysis of the blog as a genre, for example, demonstrated the continued relevance of RGS concepts for understanding how new recurrent situations give rise to new typified responses.

10 Conclusion

Rhetorical Genre Studies, inaugurated by Carolyn Miller's reconception of genre as social action and elaborated by scholars including Bazerman, Devitt, and Swales, has fundamentally transformed how we understand the relationship between writing and social life. By insisting that genres are not merely textual forms but typified social actions embedded in and constitutive of communities, RGS has provided a theoretically rich and practically generative framework for the study and teaching of writing. Its influence on ESP, professional communication, and Writing in the Disciplines continues to grow, even as scholars work to address its limitations and extend its reach to new communicative contexts.

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